TYPOGRAPHY

SPECIMEN BOOK

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GRAF155-WLA-FINAL PROJECT

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PROJECT OVERVIEW

Objective

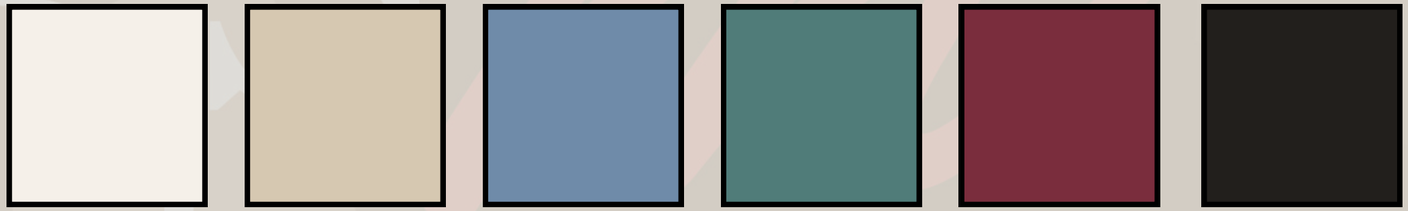
The goal of this project was to design a professional typography specimen book that explores the history, anatomy, and real-world applications of influential typefaces. The book demonstrates how typography communicates meaning through structure, hierarchy, and visual design while applying editorial layout principles learned throughout the course.

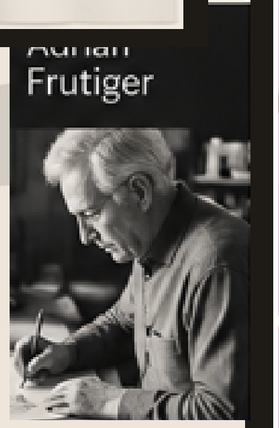
PROJECT OVERVIEW

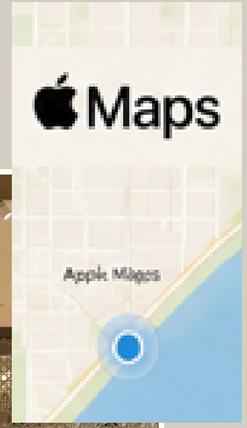
Goals

- Research influential type designers
- Explore different type classifications
- Apply editorial layout principles
- Develop a cohesive visual identity
- Create a publication-ready specimen book

MOODBOARD







A Typography g

Elegant Serif

clean sans serif

BUILDING THE VISUAL LANGUAGE

The editorial style combines minimal layouts with expressive typography. Oversized letterforms, strong hierarchy, and balanced compositions create pages that are both informative and visually engaging.

The colour palette reinforces this direction by using warm neutrals contrasted with muted blue and burgundy accents.

TYPE TRIALS

Before selecting the final typefaces, I experimented with different serif and sans-serif families to compare readability, personality, and hierarchy.

Testing different weights, sizes, and spacing helped determine how each typeface performed in editorial layouts while maintaining consistency throughout the publication.

RESEARCH PROCESS

Research formed the foundation of the project.
For each typeface I investigated:

- Designer
- History
- Classification
- Anatomy
- Character set
- Weights
- Applications

This research helped explain not only how the fonts were created but also why they continue to influence modern design.

LAYOUT DEVELOPMENT

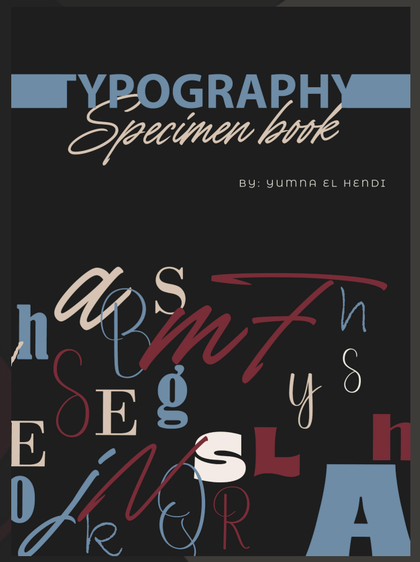
The specimen book was built using an editorial grid, consistent margins, and paragraph styles to ensure alignment and visual consistency across every spread.

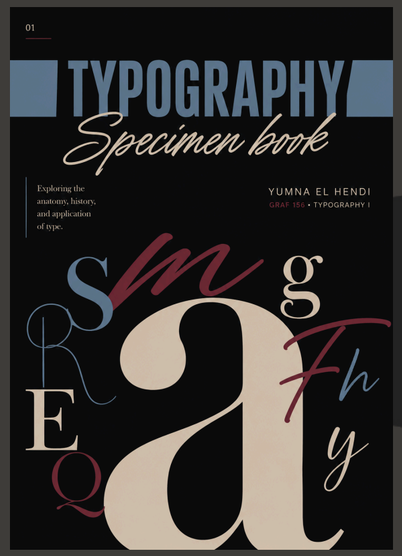
Oversized background letterforms became a key design element, adding depth and emphasizing the character of each typeface. Combined with layered typography, colour, and imagery, these elements created bold editorial compositions while maintaining clear hierarchy and readability.

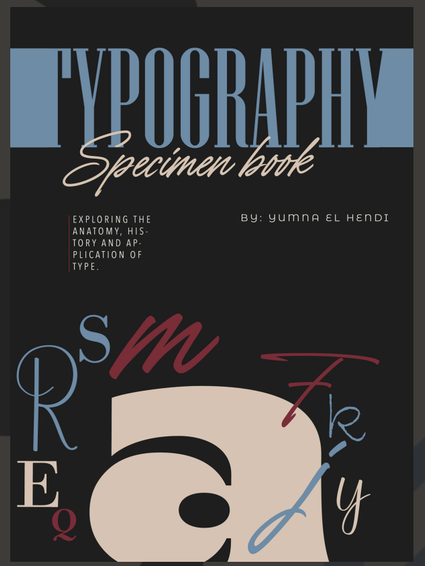
I actually think this version describes your book much more accurately than mentioning white space, because the oversized letters are one of the most distinctive features of your final design.

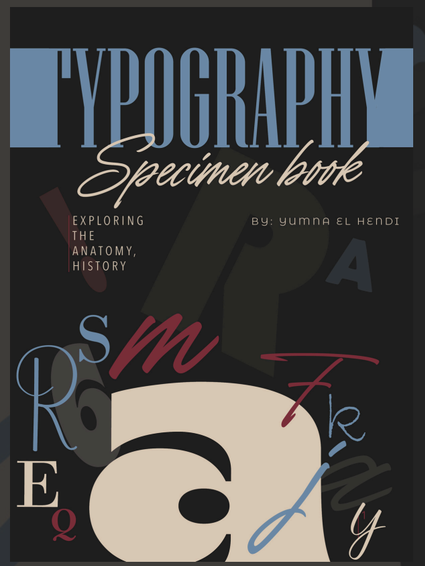
COVER DEVELOPMENT

The cover evolved through several concepts before reaching the final design.
Early versions explored different compositions and typography before refining the layout into a bold editorial cover featuring layered letterforms, expressive typography, and a limited colour palette that reflects the overall aesthetic of the book.









DESIGNER SPOTLIGHT

Adrian Frutiger

Adrian Frutiger was one of the most influential type designers of the twentieth century.

His philosophy emphasized clarity, readability, and functionality while maintaining timeless elegance.

His work transformed transportation systems, branding, publishing, and digital interfaces, making his typefaces among the most recognizable in the world.

AVENIR

AVENIR
HUMANIST SANS SERIF

Designer
Adrian Frutiger

Released
1988

Classification
Humanist Sans Serif

Avenir was designed by Adrian Frutiger in 1988 as a modern interpretation of the geometric sans serif tradition. While inspired by classic geometric typefaces such as Futura, Avenir introduces subtle optical adjustments that improve readability and give the letters a warmer, more human appearance. Today it is widely used in branding, editorial design, signage, and digital interfaces because of its clarity and versatility.

Character Set
ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz
0123456789
! ? @ # $ % & * ( )

Anatomy
Round terminals
Open counters
Balanced x-height
Geometric circles
Humanist proportions

Weights
Ultra Light
Condensed
Roman
Medium
Bold Condensed
Heavy

Applications

LG

6

a

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRS
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvw
0123456789

0123456789

"A typeface should never call attention to itself."

– Adrian Frutiger

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Designed by Adrian Frutiger in 1988, Avenir is a Humanist Sans Serif that combines geometric precision with excellent readability.

Its balanced proportions and clean forms make it ideal for branding, editorial design, digital interfaces, and wayfinding systems.

I selected Avenir because it communicates clarity while remaining warm and approachable.

BASKERVILLE

Created in 1757 by John Baskerville, Baskerville is a Transitional Serif known for its elegant proportions, increased stroke contrast, and exceptional readability.

Its timeless appearance makes it popular in publishing, luxury branding, and academic literature.

I chose Baskerville because it represents refinement while remaining highly functional.

BODONI

BODONI
MODERN (DIDONE) SERIF

Designer
Giambattista Bodoni

Released
1798

Bodoni was designed by Italian typographer Giambattista Bodoni and published in 1798. It represents the Modern, or Didone, style of typography, characterized by dramatic contrast between thick and thin strokes, vertical stress, and refined serifs. Bodoni became a symbol of elegance and precision, and it remains widely used in luxury branding, fashion magazines, book publishing, and editorial design because of its sophisticated appearance.

Classification
Modern (Didone) Serif

Character Set
ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz
0123456789
! ? @ # $ % & * ( )

Anatomy
High stroke contrast
Hairline serifs
Vertical stress
Geometric precision
Elegant proportions

Weights
Poster Compressed
Condensed
Condensed Italic
Condensed Bold
Condensed Bold Italic
Regular
Italic
Bold
Bold Italic
Black
Black Italic

Applications

Dior

B

ABCDEFGHIJKLM
abcdefghijklmnopqrstu
0123456789

0123456789

"Letters should combine beauty with usefulness."

– Giambattista Bodoni

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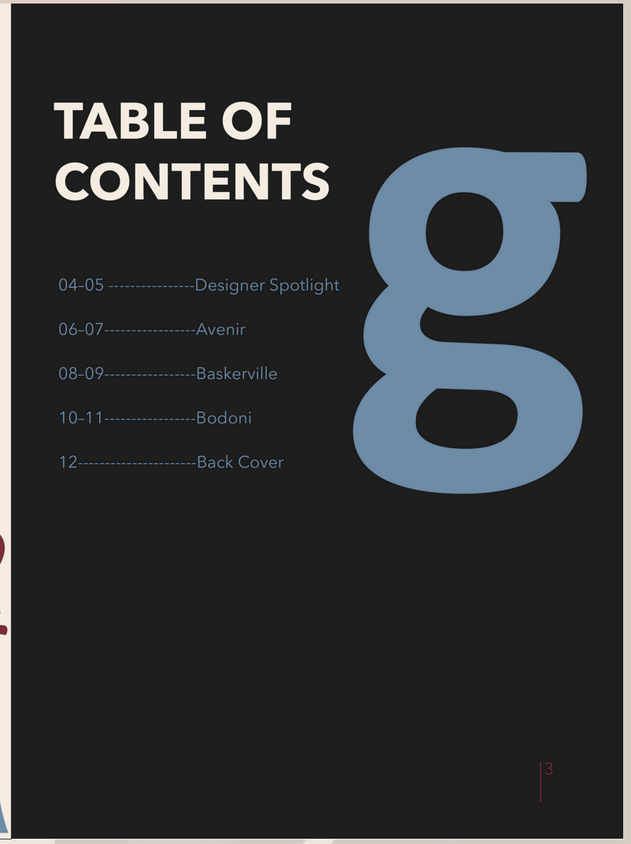
Designed by Giambattista Bodoni in 1798, Bodoni is a Modern (Didone) Serif characterized by dramatic contrast, refined serifs, and geometric precision.
Its sophisticated appearance has made it a favourite in fashion magazines, luxury branding, and editorial design.
I selected Bodoni because it demonstrates how typography can express elegance and confidence.

THE FINAL PRODUCTION

The completed specimen book brings together research, typography, layout, and visual storytelling into a cohesive editorial publication.

Every spread was designed to balance readability with visual impact while maintaining consistency through colour, hierarchy, and spacing.



REFLECTION

This project significantly improved my understanding of typography and editorial design. Researching type classifications and the designers behind each typeface helped me appreciate how typography influences communication beyond simply choosing a font.

The most interesting part of the project was discovering how each typeface has its own history, personality, and intended purpose.

My favourite typeface is Avenir because of its clean, modern appearance and outstanding readability.

The biggest challenge was creating consistent layouts that balanced large display typography with body text while maintaining visual hierarchy.

The greatest success was producing a cohesive specimen book that combines research, design principles, and editorial aesthetics into a unified publication.

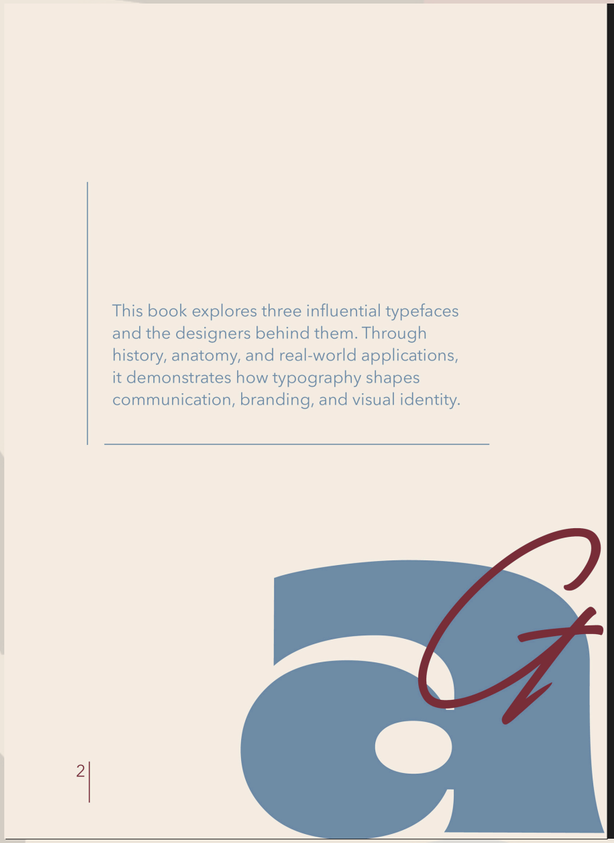
If I were to continue developing this project, I would expand the research section and experiment with additional interactive or digital applications of typography.

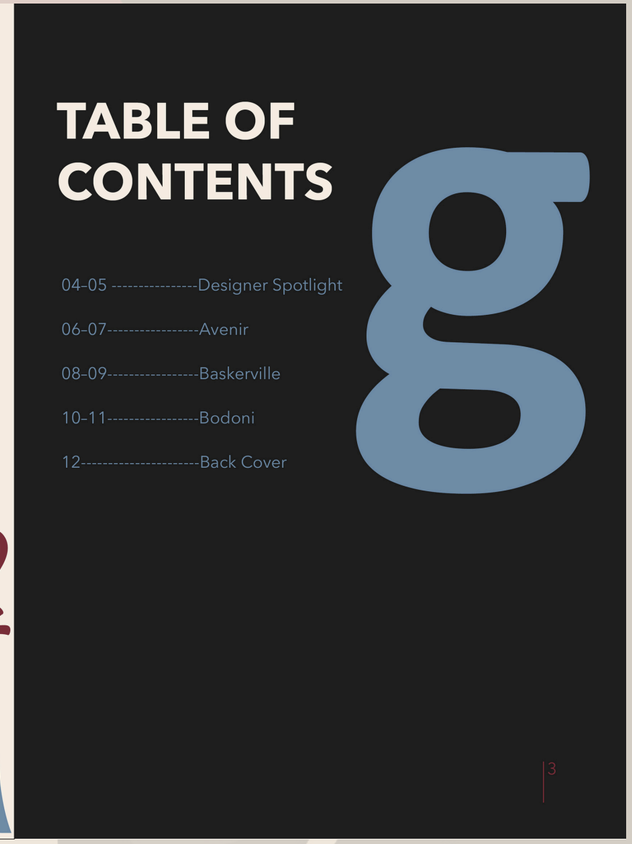
REFERENCES & AI

- Manuale Tipografico — Giambattista Bodoni
- The Elements of Typographic Style — Robert Bringhurst
- Signs and Symbols — Adrian Frutiger
- Meggs' History of Graphic Design — Meggs & Purvis

AI Acknowledgement

ChatGPT was used to assist with refining written content, organizing historical summaries, and proofreading text. All research selection, design decisions, layouts, and final visual execution were completed independently.





THANK YOU